Central Asia around 4000 BC and we know that a millennium later, the Harappans had a trading outpost on the Amu Darya. Surely they would have noticed how the locals had tamed an animal that could be so useful. In fact, it would not be surprising if they were there to procure horses. After all, the importation of horses remains a common theme throughout later Indian history. Thus, one could argue that it was the horse and not the Aryan who was imported. Indeed, there is independent evidence to suggest horses were familiar animals even in Central India from a very early stage. The stone-age rock paintings of Bhimbetka show horses. The Neolithic site of Mahagara on the Belan river has yielded horse bones—which may indicate a familiarity with the animal from a pre-Harappan era! [17] In short, there may have been plenty of horses about, which fits with the fact that the so-called non-Aryan tribes in the Rig Veda also appear to have horses of their own.

Second, it is not entirely true that there are no signs of the horse in Harappan sites. While the horse is not depicted in any of the seals, there are at least two terracotta figurines that depict a 'horse-like' creature. The set of 'chessmen' found in Lothal, too, has a piece that looks like a horse's head. There are even claims that horse bones have been found in a few places and have been positively identified by leading scholars [18] although critics still argue that these remains are of asses/donkeys and not of horses. I am not qualified to judge this but merely want readers to know that the absence of horses can no longer be evoked quite so easily to debunk the idea that the Harappans and the Vedic people were somehow related. In my view, the really interesting debate relates to lions and not horses. We will visit it in the next chapter.

On balance, the evidence appears to have tipped in favour of the archaeologists rather than the historians. New information—including genetic data—appears to be strengthening their hand. Over time, it is possible that the remaining controversies will be ironed out including that of the horse and the lion. My own sense is that the Harappans were a multi-